

can use this in production in non-critical applications, bearing in mind that it needs to be self-supported with the help of community resources. If this edition caters to your business needs, then it is the most cost-effective solution.

With any of these editions, you will find that Alfresco is a complete document management solution for your content needs. Let's get to know the basic capabilities of Alfresco. Here are nine key features that will help you get the most out of your content using Alfresco.

A perfect collaboration tool

While working in a team, it is essential to collaborate effectively in order to get better productivity. Hence, the collaboration tool plays an important role. Out-of-the-box Alfresco installation provides a UI interface called Alfresco Share, which comes with an easy-to-use collaboration platform to effectively collaborate within a team using the wiki, blog, calendar and so on.

Workflow capability to simplify business processes

Capturing or creating content without any approval process may lead to content chaos, with unwanted content getting added in the repository. Hence, it becomes necessary to validate the content being added to the repository. Alfresco, with the integrated workflow engine, makes this possible and allows users to define approval processes to validate the content before making it available for general use.

Secured access to content with robust permission modelling

The content repository may have a large amount of data residing in it. There may be different types of users such as content creators, content reviewers, internal team members, customers and so on who will be accessing the repository. Not all content can be accessed by everyone. One should only be able to access what one is allowed to. Hence, providing appropriate permission to content is a must. In Alfresco, with the robust permission modelling, it is easy to provide secure access to the content based on requirements.

Content on-the-go with an effective search mechanism

In a large-sized repository, what if you want to access some specific content based on your requirements? Manually going to each folder to locate the required content is not a desirable option. What if a robust search mechanism is available which will get you the results based on your search criteria? This makes your life a lot easier. Yes, Alfresco does provide search capabilities based on metadata of the content and also from the body of the content, allowing you to easily find what you are looking for.

External applications can be easily integrated with Alfresco

Just in order to understand integration capabilities with

Alfresco, let's take a look at some available options. It may be that you already have a frontend application and you just want to use Alfresco as a backend repository. REST APIs and CMIS make it easy for other applications to interact with the Alfresco content repository in a secured way. Also, it is easy to configure Alfresco with authentication systems such as LDAP, Active Directory and so on. Being able to integrate external systems with Alfresco in a hassle-free manner is also one of the reasons why it is a preferred choice amongst technical architects.

Transformation of content from one format to another

One of the key requirements while working with content is to transform content from one form to another. For example, while drafting a contract, the document which is in a Word format will undergo a review by the legal team, the finance team and so on in a well-defined workflow process. At the end of the review process, the contract becomes active and you will want to convert the Word document to a non-editable PDF. With content transformation capabilities, this is easily done in Alfresco.

Versioning capability allows users to maintain different versions of content

In a well-defined workflow review process, your content may be reviewed by teams of experts and by you, and while adhering to their review comments, you can make modifications to the content. With Alfresco's versioning capability, you can create new versions of the content and easily keep track of every version.

The ability to specify business rules

Business rules help users perform some important actions based on some predefined conditions. For example, based on the value of some metadata like the status of a contract under review, you may need to move the content to the *Review* folder, and if contract status is active, move it to the *Active* folder in order to effectively classify the content. Alfresco allows users to easily set up such business rules.

Auditing the content

Along with secured access to the content, it is equally important that you know who accessed what. This is easily tracked with the auditing capabilities provided in Alfresco.

These are just a few basic features of Alfresco to familiarise you with its capabilities. If you are looking for an open source ECM for your business and are evaluating various alternatives, then Alfresco must be explored. 

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